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Govt, charities grapple as India's flood death toll crosses 1,500

Death toll climbed after another 18 people were killed in flooding in two states this week



A view of village home after flooding hit various areas in Uttarakhand state of India. (Photo: Caritas India)

By Michael Gonsalves

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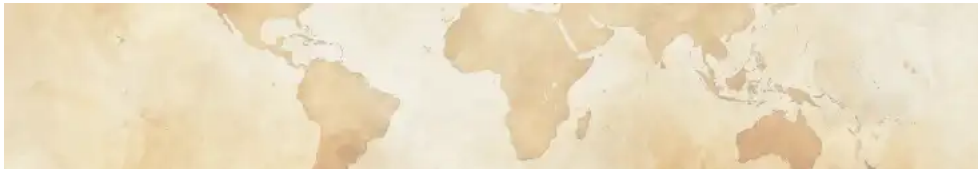


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Government agencies and aid groups in India have been grappling to assist victims as flooding continues to affect various states across the country.

The recent flooding in two northern states, Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh, on Sept. 15-16, resulted in at least 18 deaths, with 16 people missing and thousands stranded.

Since the start of the monsoon in June, approximately 1,500 people have died due to rain, landslides, and related road accidents. Thousands have also been displaced.



At least 15 Indian states have witnessed heavy flooding since June, affecting millions. Among the worst-hit states are Himachal Pradesh, Kerala, Bihar, Punjab, and Jammu and Kashmir.

The intensity of rain and cloudbursts during this year’s monsoon left a trail of devastation, said Navneet Yadav, who heads the disaster aid and management department of Catholic charity Caritas India.

“Himachal Pradesh bore the brunt this year, accounting for 400 deaths, followed by Kerala 335, Andhra Pradesh 258, Jammu and Kashmir 130, Bihar 98, and Punjab 55,” Yadav told UCA News.

In Himachal alone, the estimated flood damage cost is over 4 billion rupees, he said.

In Shimla, the capital city of Himachal Pradesh, on Sept. 16, a landslide buried several vehicles in the city center, blocking the main circular road and causing problems for school-going children.

“It was raining heavily, and around 1 am, we heard a deafening sound with trees and debris sliding down, and we immediately moved our vehicles to escape,” said Gautam Shukla, who was sleeping in a vehicle with his friend Rahul when the landslide struck.

In Punjab, at least 55 people died and about 380,000 were affected by the worst flooding in decades, according to a Caritas report.

On Sept. 14, the Punjab state government said a total of 20 million rupees (US\$235,000) were distributed to 50 families who lost their members in flooding, and another six families are also set to receive compensation soon.

In August, at least 68 people died and 300 were injured in the Jammu and Kashmir region due to flooding and landslides. At least 30 victims were Hindu pilgrims trekking to a famous mountain temple in Jammu when a landslide struck.

Caritas has reached victims across Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Manipur, Bihar, Kerala, Telangana, and Kashmir with relief supplies and hygiene kits, and assessments for rehabilitation are underway, Yadav said.

He added that the agency had allocated over 40 million rupees (approximately US\$47,000) for flood response nationwide.

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Cardinal Filipe Neri Ferrao, president of the Conference of Catholic Bishops of India, the apex body of Latin-rite bishops, issued a circular on Sept. 13, urging Catholics and Church-run institutes to offer prayer and financial support for flood victims.

"More than 1,500 people lost their lives, numerous have lost their livelihoods, and over 100,000 families are suffering severely, with many people still missing, and the death toll is rising by the day," he said.

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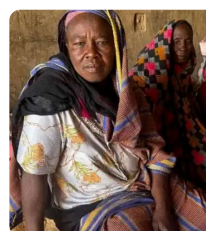
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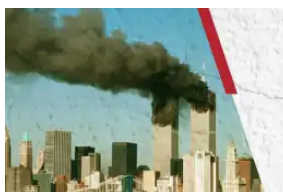


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